

PTSD RECOVERY WORKBOOK

Reclaim Your Life After Trauma

Evidence-Based Exercises for Healing,
Understanding, and Moving Forward

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PTSD RECOVERY WORKBOOK

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This workbook is not a substitute for professional treatment.

If you are in crisis, call 988 or go to your nearest ER.

UNDERSTANDING PTSD

Post-Traumatic Stress Disorder (PTSD) is a normal response to abnormal events.

It is NOT a sign of weakness. It means your brain is trying to protect you.

WHAT CAUSES PTSD:

- Combat/military service - Physical or sexual assault
- Childhood abuse or neglect - Natural disasters
- Serious accidents - Witnessing violence
- Medical trauma - Sudden loss of loved one

PTSD SYMPTOMS (you don't need all of them):

RE-EXPERIENCING: Flashbacks, nightmares, intrusive memories, emotional reactions to triggers that remind you of the trauma.

AVOIDANCE: Avoiding places, people, activities, thoughts, or feelings associated with the trauma. Emotional numbness.

HYPERAROUSAL: Being on edge, easily startled, difficulty sleeping, irritability, difficulty concentrating, hypervigilance.

NEGATIVE CHANGES IN THOUGHTS/MOOD: Negative beliefs about self/world, blame, diminished interest, feeling detached, inability to feel positive.

IMPORTANT: PTSD is TREATABLE. Recovery is possible at any stage. Effective treatments include CPT, PE, EMDR, and medication.

TRAUMA RESPONSE TYPES

Your body has 4 survival responses. Understanding yours helps healing.

FIGHT RESPONSE:

- Anger, rage, desire to control
- Difficulty letting things go, argumentative
- Tight jaw, clenched fists, confrontational
- May look like: aggression, bullying, perfectionism

FLIGHT RESPONSE:

- Anxiety, restlessness, panic
- Overworking, over-exercising, staying busy
- Can't sit still, always planning escape routes
- May look like: workaholism, perfectionism, rushing

FREEZE RESPONSE:

- Numbness, dissociation, 'spacing out'
- Difficulty making decisions, feeling stuck
- Brain fog, feeling disconnected from body
- May look like: depression, isolation, zoning out

FAWN RESPONSE:

- People-pleasing, inability to say no
- Putting others' needs above your own always
- Losing sense of self, over-apologizing
- May look like: codependency, no boundaries

MY PRIMARY RESPONSE(S): _____

How this shows up in my daily life: _____

MY SAFETY PLAN

Complete this plan NOW, while you are feeling stable.

Keep it accessible for crisis moments.

WARNING SIGNS that a crisis is developing:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

COPING STRATEGIES I can do alone:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

PEOPLE I can call for support:

Name: _____ Phone: _____

Name: _____ Phone: _____

SAFE PLACES I can go:

1. _____
2. _____

PROFESSIONAL CONTACTS:

Therapist: _____ Phone: _____

Psychiatrist: _____ Phone: _____

Crisis line: 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline)

Crisis text: Text HOME to 741741

Emergency: 911

THINGS WORTH LIVING FOR (list at least 5):

1. _____ 2. _____ 3. _____
4. _____ 5. _____

GROUNDING TECHNIQUES

Grounding brings you back to the PRESENT when triggered.

TECHNIQUE 1: 5-4-3-2-1 (Sensory Grounding)

Name 5 things you can SEE: _____

Name 4 things you can TOUCH: _____

Name 3 things you can HEAR: _____

Name 2 things you can SMELL: _____

Name 1 thing you can TASTE: _____

TECHNIQUE 2: Body Scan

Starting at your feet, slowly notice each body part.

Feet on the floor. Legs supported by the chair.

Hands in your lap. Shoulders dropping. Jaw unclenching.

Say: 'I am here. I am safe. This is now, not then.'

TECHNIQUE 3: Safe Place Visualization

Close your eyes. Imagine a place where you feel completely safe.

My safe place is: _____

What I see there: _____

What I hear there: _____

What I feel there: _____

What makes it safe: _____

TECHNIQUE 4: Temperature Change

Hold ice cubes, splash cold water on face, or drink cold water.

This activates the dive reflex and calms your nervous system.

TECHNIQUE 5: Mental Games

Count backward from 100 by 7s. Name all 50 states.

List every color you can think of. Spell your name backward.

TRIGGER IDENTIFICATION WORKSHEET

Triggers are reminders of trauma. They can be obvious or subtle.

Identifying them gives you power to prepare and respond.

SENSORY TRIGGERS:

Sounds: _____

Smells: _____

Sights: _____

Touch/physical sensations: _____

Tastes: _____

SITUATIONAL TRIGGERS:

Places: _____

Times of day/year: _____

People/relationship types: _____

Activities: _____

EMOTIONAL TRIGGERS:

Feeling helpless: _____

Feeling trapped: _____

Feeling out of control: _____

INTERNAL TRIGGERS:

Physical pain: _____

Fatigue: _____

Hunger: _____

MY TOP 5 TRIGGERS & MY PLAN FOR EACH:

1. Trigger: _____ Plan: _____

2. Trigger: _____ Plan: _____

3. Trigger: _____ Plan: _____

4. Trigger: _____ Plan: _____

5. Trigger: _____ Plan: _____

WINDOW OF TOLERANCE

The 'Window of Tolerance' is the zone where you can function well.

HYPERAROUSAL (above the window):

- Anxiety, panic, rage, hypervigilance
- Racing thoughts, inability to rest
- Fight or flight mode activated

---- WINDOW OF TOLERANCE (ideal zone) ----

- Calm but alert, able to think clearly
- Can manage emotions, connect with others
- Feel present and grounded

HYPOAROUSAL (below the window):

- Numbness, disconnection, depression
- Foggy thinking, flat emotions
- Freeze or collapse mode activated

EXPANDING YOUR WINDOW:

The goal is to WIDEN your window of tolerance over time.

Practices that expand the window:

- Regular grounding exercises
- Mindfulness meditation (start with 2 minutes)
- Safe physical movement (yoga, walking)
- Therapy (especially EMDR, Somatic Experiencing)
- Social connection with safe people
- Consistent sleep schedule

Right now, my window feels: Narrow / Medium / Wide

I tend to go: Above / Below / Both directions

COPING STRATEGIES MENU

Choose strategies from each category. Star your favorites.

PHYSICAL (body-based):

- ☐ Deep breathing (box breathing: 4-4-4-4)
- ☐ Progressive muscle relaxation
- ☐ Walk or exercise
- ☐ Cold water on face/wrists
- ☐ Yoga or stretching
- ☐ Dance or movement

COGNITIVE (thought-based):

- ☐ Challenge catastrophic thoughts
- ☐ Remind yourself: 'That was THEN, this is NOW'
- ☐ Use a coping statement card
- ☐ Journaling
- ☐ List facts about the present moment

SENSORY (using your senses):

- ☐ Essential oils or scented candle
- ☐ Weighted blanket
- ☐ Music playlist (calming or energizing)
- ☐ Tactile objects (smooth stone, fidget)
- ☐ Nature sounds or being in nature

SOCIAL (connection-based):

- ☐ Call a safe person
- ☐ Go somewhere with people (coffee shop, park)
- ☐ Support group (in-person or online)
- ☐ Pet an animal
- ☐ Help someone else

STUCK POINTS WORKSHEET

From Cognitive Processing Therapy

Stuck points are unhelpful beliefs that developed after trauma.
They keep you stuck in pain. Identifying them is step one.

COMMON STUCK POINTS ABOUT SAFETY:

'I can never be safe.' 'The world is completely dangerous.'

ABOUT TRUST:

'I can never trust anyone.' 'Everyone will betray me.'

ABOUT POWER/CONTROL:

'I am helpless.' 'I should have been able to stop it.'

ABOUT ESTEEM:

'I am damaged.' 'I am worthless because of what happened.'

ABOUT INTIMACY:

'I can never be close to anyone.' 'No one could love me.'

MY STUCK POINTS:

1. _____

Evidence FOR this belief: _____

Evidence AGAINST this belief: _____

More balanced thought: _____

2. _____

Evidence FOR: _____

Evidence AGAINST: _____

More balanced thought: _____

SELF-COMPASSION EXERCISES

Trauma survivors often blame themselves. Self-compassion heals.

EXERCISE 1: What Would You Tell a Friend?

If your best friend went through what you did, would you tell them it was their fault? Would you call them weak? No.

Write what you WOULD say to them: _____

Now say those same words to YOURSELF.

EXERCISE 2: Self-Compassion Break

When pain arises, say these 3 phrases:

1. 'This is a moment of suffering.' (mindfulness)
2. 'Suffering is part of being human.' (common humanity)
3. 'May I be kind to myself.' (self-kindness)

EXERCISE 3: Compassionate Letter to Yourself

Write to yourself from the perspective of a loving friend who knows everything about your trauma and sees you with unconditional compassion. What would they say?

EXERCISE 4: Daily Self-Compassion Practice

Each night, place your hand on your heart and say:

'I did the best I could today. That is enough.'

SLEEP HYGIENE FOR PTSD

Sleep disruption is one of the most common PTSD symptoms.

Better sleep does not fix PTSD, but it makes everything easier.

NIGHTTIME ROUTINE (do the same thing every night):

- ☐ Set consistent bedtime: ____:____ PM
- ☐ Set consistent wake time: ____:____ AM
- ☐ Stop screens 1 hour before bed
- ☐ Dim lights in the evening
- ☐ Do calming activity: reading, gentle stretching, bath
- ☐ Keep bedroom cool (65-68 degrees)
- ☐ Use white noise or fan if needed

FOR NIGHTMARES:

- Practice Image Rehearsal Therapy: while awake, choose a recurring nightmare and rewrite the ending to something safe. Rehearse the new version 10-20 min daily for 2 weeks.
- Keep a dim nightlight if total darkness is triggering
- Have grounding objects by your bed (smooth stone, familiar scent)
- Upon waking from nightmare: orient to the room, name 5 objects, remind yourself 'I am safe. That was then, this is now.'

FOR HYPERVIGILANCE AT NIGHT:

- Check locks ONCE (not repeatedly)
- Consider a security camera if it helps (check once only)
- Place bed where you can see the door
- Reassure yourself: 'I have done what I can. I am safe.'

FLASHBACK PROTOCOL

A flashback makes the past feel like it's happening NOW.

Use this protocol to come back to the present:

STEP 1: RECOGNIZE what is happening

Say out loud: 'I am having a flashback. This is a memory.

It is not happening right now. I am safe.'

STEP 2: GROUND yourself in the present

- Stamp your feet. Feel the floor.
- Look around. Name the room you are in.
- What year is it? What day? What time?
- Touch something real: table, wall, your own arms.

STEP 3: BREATHE slowly

- Breathe in for 4 counts
- Hold for 4 counts
- Breathe out for 6 counts
- Repeat until heart rate slows

STEP 4: COMFORT yourself

- Wrap yourself in a blanket
- Hold a warm drink
- Put on familiar, safe music
- Call a safe person if needed

STEP 5: RETURN to activity slowly

- Don't rush. Take your time.
- Drink water. Eat something small.
- You survived. You came back. You are strong.

MY SUPPORT NETWORK MAP

Recovery happens in relationship. Build your support network.

INNER CIRCLE (closest, most trusted):

1. Name: _____ Relationship: _____

How they help me: _____

2. Name: _____ Relationship: _____

How they help me: _____

MIDDLE CIRCLE (supportive, reliable):

1. Name: _____ Relationship: _____

2. Name: _____ Relationship: _____

3. Name: _____ Relationship: _____

PROFESSIONAL SUPPORT:

Therapist: _____

Psychiatrist: _____

Support group: _____

Doctor: _____

COMMUNITY RESOURCES:

Crisis line: 988

Veterans crisis: 1-800-273-8255 (Press 1)

RAINN hotline: 1-800-656-4673

Local support group: _____

PEOPLE TO AVOID DURING RECOVERY:

(Those who minimize, blame, or trigger you)

WEEKLY SYMPTOM TRACKER - WEEK 1

Rate 0-10: 0=none 5=moderate 10=severe

Day	Flashbacks	Nightmares	Anxiety	Avoidance	Mood
-----	------------	------------	---------	-----------	------

Mon	___/10	___/10	___/10	___/10	___/10
Tue	___/10	___/10	___/10	___/10	___/10
Wed	___/10	___/10	___/10	___/10	___/10
Thu	___/10	___/10	___/10	___/10	___/10
Fri	___/10	___/10	___/10	___/10	___/10
Sat	___/10	___/10	___/10	___/10	___/10
Sun	___/10	___/10	___/10	___/10	___/10

Triggers this week:

Coping strategies used:

Wins this week (no matter how small):

WEEKLY SYMPTOM TRACKER - WEEK 2

Rate 0-10: 0=none 5=moderate 10=severe

Day	Flashbacks	Nightmares	Anxiety	Avoidance	Mood
-----	------------	------------	---------	-----------	------

Mon	___/10	___/10	___/10	___/10	___/10
Tue	___/10	___/10	___/10	___/10	___/10
Wed	___/10	___/10	___/10	___/10	___/10
Thu	___/10	___/10	___/10	___/10	___/10
Fri	___/10	___/10	___/10	___/10	___/10
Sat	___/10	___/10	___/10	___/10	___/10
Sun	___/10	___/10	___/10	___/10	___/10

Triggers this week:

Coping strategies used:

Wins this week (no matter how small):

WEEKLY SYMPTOM TRACKER - WEEK 3

Rate 0-10: 0=none 5=moderate 10=severe

Day	Flashbacks	Nightmares	Anxiety	Avoidance	Mood
-----	------------	------------	---------	-----------	------

Mon	___/10	___/10	___/10	___/10	___/10
Tue	___/10	___/10	___/10	___/10	___/10
Wed	___/10	___/10	___/10	___/10	___/10
Thu	___/10	___/10	___/10	___/10	___/10
Fri	___/10	___/10	___/10	___/10	___/10
Sat	___/10	___/10	___/10	___/10	___/10
Sun	___/10	___/10	___/10	___/10	___/10

Triggers this week:

Coping strategies used:

Wins this week (no matter how small):

WEEKLY SYMPTOM TRACKER - WEEK 4

Rate 0-10: 0=none 5=moderate 10=severe

Day	Flashbacks	Nightmares	Anxiety	Avoidance	Mood
-----	------------	------------	---------	-----------	------

Mon	___/10	___/10	___/10	___/10	___/10
Tue	___/10	___/10	___/10	___/10	___/10
Wed	___/10	___/10	___/10	___/10	___/10
Thu	___/10	___/10	___/10	___/10	___/10
Fri	___/10	___/10	___/10	___/10	___/10
Sat	___/10	___/10	___/10	___/10	___/10
Sun	___/10	___/10	___/10	___/10	___/10

Triggers this week:

Coping strategies used:

Wins this week (no matter how small):

RECOVERY MILESTONES

Recovery is not linear. Celebrate every step forward.

Check off milestones as you reach them:

- ☐ I acknowledged that what happened was not my fault
- ☐ I told someone safe about my trauma
- ☐ I identified my triggers
- ☐ I used a grounding technique successfully
- ☐ I slept through the night
- ☐ I went somewhere I was avoiding
- ☐ I felt a positive emotion (joy, peace, love)
- ☐ I set a boundary with someone
- ☐ I asked for help
- ☐ I went a full day without intrusive memories
- ☐ I felt safe in my body
- ☐ I trusted someone new
- ☐ I forgave myself for something
- ☐ I found meaning or purpose in my experience
- ☐ I helped another trauma survivor

MY PERSONAL MILESTONES:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Date I started this workbook: _____

Where I was then: _____

Where I am now: _____

PROFESSIONAL RESOURCES

This workbook is a supplement, not a replacement for therapy.

Here are evidence-based treatments for PTSD:

RECOMMENDED THERAPIES:

- Cognitive Processing Therapy (CPT): Challenges stuck points
- Prolonged Exposure (PE): Gradually facing avoided memories
- EMDR: Eye Movement Desensitization and Reprocessing
- Somatic Experiencing: Body-based trauma processing
- DBT: Dialectical Behavior Therapy (skills for regulation)

HOW TO FIND A THERAPIST:

- Psychology Today therapist directory (filter by 'trauma')
- EMDR International Association directory
- VA mental health services (veterans)
- Ask your primary care doctor for a referral

CRISIS RESOURCES:

- 988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline (call or text 988)
- Crisis Text Line: Text HOME to 741741
- Veterans Crisis Line: 1-800-273-8255 (Press 1)
- RAINN (sexual assault): 1-800-656-4673
- National DV Hotline: 1-800-799-7233

BOOKS RECOMMENDED:

- 'The Body Keeps the Score' by Bessel van der Kolk
- 'Complex PTSD: From Surviving to Thriving' by Pete Walker
- 'Waking the Tiger' by Peter Levine

You deserve healing. You deserve peace. Keep going.